

Digital Menschen

The Ten Commandments of Ethical Online Behavior

Rooted in Jewish Values • Informed by Youth Voices • Calibrated for the AI Era

A guide for Jewish communities, camps, youth groups,
schools, and families navigating the digital age
with wisdom, compassion, and intention.

A project of URJ 6 Points Sci-Tech Academy

Guided by Rabbi Dan Medwin

Supported by Sinai and Synapses, CLAL, and The Templeton Foundation

Introduction

Jewish tradition has always understood that how we speak to and about one another is a sacred act. The laws of *lashon hara* (harmful speech), the ethics of *derech erez* (basic decency), and the vision of *tikkun olam* (repairing the world) were articulated long before the internet existed, yet they speak directly to the challenges of digital life.

Today's teens are growing up in a world where nearly half of them are online almost constantly (Pew Research, 2024). They navigate complex social dynamics across platforms, face cyberbullying and misinformation, and struggle with the mental health effects of curated digital lives. And now, a powerful new dimension has emerged: 64% of U.S. teens have used AI chatbots, with nearly a third using them daily (Pew Research, 2025). AI companions, AI-assisted schoolwork, AI-generated images and text: these are no longer futuristic concerns. They are the daily reality of the young people in our care.

These Ten Commandments of Ethical Online Behavior draw on the deep wells of Jewish wisdom to offer a moral framework for digital life in the age of social media and artificial intelligence. Rather than treating AI as a separate topic, these commandments weave AI's ethical challenges into the same timeless values that guide all human interaction. The questions AI raises about honesty, dignity, effort, stewardship, and connection are not new questions. They are ancient questions in new clothing.

The commandments are arranged in four groups that move from the personal to the communal. The first four address how we see and treat other people, from recognizing the Divine image in every person to actively choosing kindness. The fifth and sixth address how we navigate information and privacy in an age of AI. The seventh and eighth turn inward, exploring the value of genuine effort in learning and the practice of sacred rest. The final two look outward to the wider world, calling us to pursue justice for those who are left behind and to take responsibility for the impact our digital choices have on the planet.

Each commandment is grounded in a specific Jewish value and informed by current research on what teens experience, want, and hope for in their online interactions. They are intended to inspire conversation, not to prescribe rigid rules. They are meant to open doors to reflection and growth for people of all ages.

*Derech erez kadma l'Torah: Basic human decency precedes even Torah itself.
(Vayikra Rabbah 9:3)*

The Ten Commandments of Ethical Online Behavior

I. Recognize the Divine in Every Person You Encounter Online

Jewish Value: *B'tzelem Elohim - Created in the Divine Image* - בְּצֶלֶם אֱלֹהִים

The Torah teaches, “And God created the human in the Divine image” (Genesis 1:27). Behind every screen name, profile picture, and comment is a human being who carries that image. That means the person on the other end of your screen carries infinite worth and dignity, even when you disagree with them, even when you can't see their face, and even if it's easier to dismiss them as bots or AI. *B'tzelem Elohim* asks us to look for the Divine in every person we encounter online, and to let that recognition shape how we type, share, and respond. In an age of deepfakes and AI-generated content, this becomes even more urgent: when the line between real and artificial blurs, holding onto the humanity of the people affected by what we share is an act of radical sacred attention. What would change about your next comment, post, or share if you truly saw the person on the other end as someone created in the image of God?

What Teens Are Saying: *48% of teens now say social media has a negative impact on people their age (Pew, 2024). Teens want to feel seen as whole human beings online, not reduced to likes, followers, or a single post.*

II. Guard Your Tongue: Whether You Type the Words or AI Does

Jewish Value: *Shmirat HaLashon - Guarding One's Speech* - שְׁמִירַת הַלָּשׁוֹן

The Book of Proverbs warns, “Death and life are in the power of the tongue” (Proverbs 18:21). Jewish tradition teaches that harmful speech, *lashon hara*, can wound as deeply as any weapon. Online, words travel faster, reach further, and last forever. Do not gossip, shame, mock, or spread rumors, even when you think no one will trace it back to you. *Shmirat halashon* extends to AI-assisted communication: if you use a chatbot to draft a message, generate a caption, or write a comment, you are still responsible for every word. An algorithm cannot absolve you of *lashon hara* – toxic speech. Read what AI writes for you with the same moral care you would give your own words.

Before you hit send, ask: would I say this to someone's face, and does it matter who wrote the words?

What Teens Are Saying: *46% of U.S. teens have experienced at least one form of cyberbullying, with offensive name-calling being the most common (Pew, 2022). More than half say cyberbullying is a major problem for people their age (Pew, 2024). Teens are clear: harmful words online cause real harm, whether those words come from humans or are generated by AI tools.*

III. Honor and Protect the Dignity of Every Person

Jewish Value: *K'vod HaAdam - Human Dignity - קְבוֹד הָאָדָם*

Do not humiliate anyone publicly. The Talmud teaches that publicly shaming another person is akin to shedding blood (Talmud Bava Metzia 58b). Never share someone else's private images, messages, or personal information without their consent. Do not participate in pile-ons, and do not stand silently while someone is being attacked online. Be an upstander, not a bystander. *K'vod HaAdam* also means refusing to use AI tools to create content that degrades another person: deepfake images, mocking voice imitations, or fabricated screenshots. The ease of creating such content with AI makes it no less cruel; it makes it more dangerous.

If you saw someone being attacked online right now, what would it take for you to step in?

What Teens Are Saying: *Cyberbullying continues to rise among U.S. youth (Cyberbullying Research Center, 2023). AI tools have added new dimensions to harassment, including AI-generated fake images. Teens want allies who will speak up, not just "not participate." They want communities that actively protect members.*

IV. Practice Derech Eretz and Choose Chesed: Be Decent, Be Kind, Be a Mensch

Jewish Values: *Derech Eretz - The Way of Common Decency - דֶּרֶךְ עֶרֶץ*

Chesed - Loving-Kindness - חֶסֶד

The Sages teach that *derech eretz*, basic decency and respect, comes before Torah itself (Vayikra Rabbah 9:3). Online spaces are real social spaces with real consequences. Be courteous. When you disagree, do so respectfully. Welcome newcomers. Use the same manners you would use face to face. But *derech eretz* is only the beginning. Jewish tradition also calls us to *chesed*, active loving-kindness. The world is sustained by three things: Torah, worship, and acts of loving-kindness (Pirkei Avot 1:2). Don't just avoid causing harm; be the person who encourages others, celebrates their successes, and offers support when someone is struggling. A kind comment can change someone's entire day. In a world where AI can

generate endless content, the most valuable thing you can offer is something no algorithm can produce: genuine human warmth and care. Choose to be the real voice in someone's feed that makes them feel less alone.

What is one way you could bring genuine chesed into someone's digital experience today?

What Teens Are Saying: *Studies show that teens identify "misunderstanding and conflict from communication that is not face-to-face" as a significant challenge (Montana State, 2024). And fewer teens credit social media as a genuine support system, down to 52% from 67% in 2022 (Pew, 2024). Teens want online spaces that feel both respectful and authentically warm, not just free of cruelty, but full of real connection.*

V. Seek Truth: Do Not Spread Falsehood, Do Not Steal What Others Have Created

Jewish Values: *Emet - Truth - אמת*
Geneivat Da'at - Theft of Mind - גניבת דעת

The Torah commands: "Distance yourself from falsehood" (Exodus 23:7). In an era of misinformation and deepfakes, this commandment is more urgent than ever. Verify before you share. Question what you see. Be honest in your own posts. Do not present a false version of yourself or others. Jewish tradition also prohibits *geneivat da'at*, literally "theft of the mind," which means deceiving others about the true nature of something. When AI generates text, art, or music, that output is built on the creative work of real human beings whose writing, art, and ideas were used to train it, often without their permission or compensation. Present AI-generated work honestly. Do not claim it as your own creation, and recognize that behind every AI output are the uncredited contributions of real artists, writers, and thinkers.

The next time you encounter content online, ask yourself: is this true, who made it, and is that transparent?

What Teens Are Saying: *30% of young Americans now get their news from social media (Edutopia, 2024). The share of teens using ChatGPT for schoolwork doubled from 13% to 26% in a single year (Pew, 2025). Many teens are finding real value in AI as a study tool, but they're also navigating harder questions about originality, credit, and intellectual property that most adults haven't figured out yet either.*

VI. Protect Privacy: What You Share Lives On

Jewish Value: *Tzniut - Modesty and Discretion* - צניעות

Judaism values modesty and discretion not as restriction but as protection of human dignity. Guard your personal boundaries online. Think carefully before sharing private information, images, or conversations. Once something is shared digitally, you lose control of it. Be aware that your data is valuable: the apps and platforms you use collect, store, and often sell information about you, from your browsing habits to your location. Be especially thoughtful about what you share with AI systems. Personal details, photos, and intimate conversations entered into AI chatbots may be stored, analyzed, and used to train future models in ways you cannot foresee or control. *Tzniut* reminds us that not everything needs to be public to be real. The prophet Micah calls us “to walk modestly with your God” (Micah 6:8).

Before you share something online or enter it into an AI chatbot, ask: does this need to be shared, and do I know where it goes next?

What Teens Are Saying: *74% of teens believe AI platforms should discourage the sharing of personal information (Common Sense Media, 2025). Yet about a quarter of teen AI companion users have shared personal details with these platforms, often without understanding how that data may be stored, sold, or used to train future models (Common Sense Media, 2025). Teens get that privacy matters. The gap is between what they value and what the platforms make easy.*

VII. Take Responsibility: True Learning Comes from the Wrestling

Jewish Value: *Arevut - Responsibility* - ערבות

Yegi'ah - The Toil of Learning - יגיעה

Jewish tradition teaches that "all Israel are responsible for one another." *Arevut* means that what we do and what we create matters beyond ourselves. In the digital age, this means taking ownership of what you post, share, and amplify. Your digital footprint is part of your character. Build it with integrity. *Arevut* also calls us to honesty about how we learn. Torah is acquired not through shortcuts but through human teachers, careful discussion with chevrotah partners, and the hard work of wrestling with ideas you don't yet understand (Pirkei Avot 6:6). Jewish learning has always been built on *yegi'ah*: the struggle itself is where growth happens. AI can hand you a polished answer in seconds, but it cannot give you the experience of sitting with a difficult text or topic, arguing it out with a partner, and arriving at understanding you earned. There is a difference between using a tool to support your learning and using a tool to skip it. When you present something to the world, whether an essay, a *d'var Torah*, or a project, let it reflect your real mind and your real effort.

The next time AI offers you a quick answer, ask: what would I learn by wrestling with this myself?

What Teens Are Saying: *Teens themselves draw lines around AI in learning: 54% say using ChatGPT for research is acceptable, but only 18% say the same for writing essays (Pew, 2025). 71% of Gen Z who encounter online risks now report seeking help or speaking to someone (Snap Digital Well-Being Index, 2025). Teens want a culture where accountability is expected, effort is valued, and asking for help is a sign of strength, not a shortcut.*

VIII. Observe Digital Shabbat: Create Sacred Boundaries with Technology

Jewish Value: *Shabbat - Sacred Rest and Boundaries - שבת*

On the seventh day, God finished the work of creation and rested (Genesis 2:2). Just as Shabbat teaches us to rest from creation, practice stepping away from your screens: from social media, from AI chatbots, from the endless scroll. Set intentional boundaries around your device use. You are more than your online presence. AI companions are designed to be always available, always agreeable, and always engaging, which can make disconnection feel harder, but also makes it more necessary. At the same time, not everyone has equal access to the human support they need: a therapist, a rabbi, a mentor, or even consistent internet. For some, AI tools can be a meaningful bridge, and online communities can offer real connection. *Shabbat* doesn't ask us to reject the tools we rely on; it asks us to be intentional about when we use them, when we rest from them, and when we turn toward the people and relationships that sustain us.

What would it look like for you to practice a digital Shabbat, even for an hour?

What Teens Are Saying: *44% of teens report trying to cut back on social media or smartphone use (Pew, 2024). 64% of teens have used AI chatbots, with 28% using them daily (Pew, 2025). 72% of teens have tried AI companions, with a third saying talking to AI feels as good as or better than talking to a real friend (Common Sense Media, 2025). Teens recognize the need for balance and are actively seeking permission and support to disconnect.*

IX. Pursue Digital Justice: Build a World That Leaves No One Behind

Jewish Value: *Tzedek - Justice and Righteousness - צדק*

"Justice, justice shall you pursue" (Deuteronomy 16:20). *Tzedek* demands that we look beyond our own experience and ask: who is missing? Not everyone has consistent access to the internet, a working device, or the subscriptions that unlock the tools others take for

granted. When we assume everyone is equally connected, we leave people out. When we build Jewish spaces online without thinking about accessibility, we close doors that should be open. *Tzedek* in the digital age means designing and choosing platforms that work for people with visual or hearing impairments, creating content that doesn't assume a single way of learning, and remembering that a community is only as strong as its commitment to including every member. AI tools hold real promise for bridging some of these gaps: translating languages, generating captions, supporting different learning styles. But only if access to those tools is itself just and equitable.

Before you build, post, or share, ask: who is this leaving out, and what can I do about it?

What Teens Are Saying: *The gap between teens from high-income families and those from low-income families in AI use reached 24 percentage points in 2025, double the gap observed in 2024 (CARE/USC, 2025). Teens in lower- and middle-income households are also less likely to have access to a home computer or tablet (Pew, 2024). The digital divide isn't just about who's online. It's about who has the tools to learn, create, and participate fully. Justice means making sure the answer isn't determined by your zip code or your family's income.*

X. Use Your Online Presence to Repair the World

Jewish Values: *Tikkun Olam - Repairing the World - תיקון עולם*
Bal Tashchit - Do Not Destroy - בל תשחית

Every post, share, and comment is an opportunity for *tikkun*, repair. Use your platform to uplift, educate, advocate, and create. Share content that builds up rather than tears down. The digital world is not separate from the real world; what you do online shapes the world we all share. Be aware, too, that our digital choices have a physical cost. AI systems consume enormous amounts of energy and water. Every query, every generated image, every chatbot conversation draws on real resources from the real earth. The Jewish principle of *bal tashchit* (do not waste or destroy) calls us to use these powerful tools mindfully, not frivolously.

Ask yourself: is this use of technology truly serving *tikkun*, or is it just convenience at the world's expense?

What Teens Are Saying: *Despite concerns, many teens still say social media helps them find creative inspiration and access helpful information (Pew, 2024). Teens increasingly care about environmental responsibility and want to understand the real-world footprint of their digital habits.*

A Final Word

The digital world is not a separate world. It is our world, an extension of our homes, our communities, our relationships. Jewish tradition teaches that every moment is an opportunity for holiness, and every encounter with another person is an encounter with the Divine. These commandments are an invitation to bring that awareness into every keystroke, every comment, every share, and every interaction with AI.

Artificial intelligence will continue to grow more powerful and more present in our lives. But technology, however sophisticated, cannot replace what makes us most human: our capacity for genuine empathy, moral reasoning, and sacred relationship. The question is not whether our teens will use these tools, but what kind of people they will be when they do.

As the Talmud reminds us: "Whoever preserves a single soul, it is as though they have preserved an entire world" (Sanhedrin 37a). In the digital age, the ways we treat one another online ripple outward in ways we may never fully see. Let us choose, in every interaction, to build a world worthy of the one God imagined.

"In a place where there are no human beings, strive to be a human being."

Pirkei Avot 2:5

An Important Note

This document was developed with the assistance of AI tools for research, drafting, and revision, modeling the kind of transparent, human-guided AI use these commandments advocate.

Sources and References

Research Studies Cited

Pew Research Center (2024). "Teens, Social Media and Technology 2024." Survey of 1,391 U.S. teens ages 13–17.

Pew Research Center (2025). "Teens, Social Media and AI Chatbots 2025." Survey of 1,458 U.S. teens ages 13–17.

Pew Research Center (2025). "Social Media and Teens' Mental Health: What Teens and Their Parents Say."

Pew Research Center (2025). "About a Quarter of U.S. Teens Have Used ChatGPT for Schoolwork."

Common Sense Media (2025). "Talk, Trust, and Trade-Offs: How and Why Teens Use AI Companions."

Snap Inc. (2025). "Digital Well-Being Index, Year 4." Survey of 9,037 respondents across six countries.

Stanford / Common Sense Media (2025). Research on AI companion safety risks for adolescents.

Cyberbullying Research Center (2023). "Cyberbullying Continues to Rise Among Youth in the United States."

Montana State University (2024). Survey on the impact of technology on adolescent romantic relationships.

Edutopia (2024). "Facilitating Respectful Digital Citizenship in the Classroom." Center for Applied Research in Education (CARE), USC (2025). Survey on AI use among teens by household income.

Jewish Textual Sources

Torah: Genesis 1:27 (B'tzelem Elohim); Genesis 2:2 (Shabbat); Exodus 23:7 ("Distance yourself from falsehood"); Genesis 1:27 (B'tzelem Elohim)

Talmud: Sanhedrin 37a (preserving a single soul); Bava Metzia 58b (public shaming); Berakhot 17a (speech and character); Chullin 94a (geneivat da'at / deception)

Mishnah: Pirkei Avot 1:2 (three pillars); Pirkei Avot 2:5 (being human); Pirkei Avot 6:6 (Torah acquired through effort and community)

Vayikra Rabbah 9:3 ("Derech erez kadma l'Torah")

Deuteronomy 16:20 (tzedek); Deuteronomy 20:19–20 (bal tashchit: prohibition against needless destruction)

Proverbs 18:21 (power of the tongue) Micah 6:8 (walking modestly with God) Chofetz Chaim: Shmirat HaLashon (laws of ethical speech)

Rambam (Maimonides): Hilchot De'ot (Laws of Character Traits); Hilchot Geneivah (Laws of Theft, including geneivat da'at)